

onset of diabetes, a relatively common illness among Afro-Caribbeans. The medical and religious customs on each Caribbean island vary, but on many they reflect the African traditions of transported slaves, especially of the Yoruba people shipped from West Africa, who carried on the practices of their homelands. In some of these traditions, herbs are valued for their magical power as well as for their medicinal properties. Tobacco (*Nicotiana tabacum*, p. 240) for example, is used for divination in many American cultures, including in Santeria and Voodoo religious rituals, as are other herbs, including garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59) and cayenne (*Capsicum frutescens*, p. 74).



A Native American medicine man performing a healing ritual intended to drive out evil spirits, as depicted by the 19th-century artist George Catlin.

Shamanism

Moving north, Native American herbal medicine in what is now the United States was and is primarily shamanistic in nature, involving herbal lore, ritual, and magic. Shamanistic societies from Siberia to the Amazon believe that, in serious illness, the soul of the sick person has been taken over by malign forces. The shaman's role is to heal both the physical and the spiritual dimension of the illness. The patient cannot be truly cured until his or her soul has been freed from evil spirits. Shamanistic ceremonies and rites to heal the sick person's spirit include dancing, chanting, drumming, playing games, and the stirring of ashes or sprinkling of water. By taking hallucinogens such as peyote (*Lophophora williamsii*, p. 230), the shaman is able to reach out to the spirit world and heal both the individual and the community as a whole.

Power of Herbs

In all Native American cultures from Canada to Chile, herbs are thought to have spiritual energy, and many of them are invested with great magical power. The Iroquois believe that cardinal lobelia (*Lobelia cardinalis*, see *L. inflata*, p. 110) and morning glory (*Ipomoea pandurata*) have the ability to heal or harm, and should be picked, stored, and used with great care. Morning glory is considered so powerful that even touching it could cause harm. The Iroquois use the plant as a remedy for coughs, tuberculosis, and other ailments, and also take it as a decoction with sunflower seeds (*Helianthus annuus*) as a sacrament in spring and autumn rituals.

Tobacco, now considered an addictive drug, was a sacred shamanistic herb for most Native American peoples. It was smoked in pipes and "thrown into fires as an offering, cast into the wind and water to abate storms, scattered about a fish weir to improve the catch, and offered to the air in thanksgiving for escape from danger," according to Virgil Vogel's *American Indian Medicine* (1970).

Wild yam (*Dioscorea villosa*, p. 91) contains steroidal saponins that have a hormonal effect. It was used to produce early versions of the birth-control pill.

Wild yam chopped rhizome

Wild yam rhizome

Lobelia tablets (*Lobelia inflata*, p. 110) help relax the small muscles of the bronchial tubes, easing asthma.

Goldenseal (*Hydrastis canadensis*, p. 105) was prized as a cure-all in the 19th century.

Pokeweed (*Phytolacca americana*, p. 247) was used in the 19th century to induce vomiting.

Skullcap (*Scutellaria lateriflora*, p. 135) is an effective relaxant.

Cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150) is a sedative and muscle relaxant, hence its common name.

Pleurisy root (*Asclepias tuberosa*, p. 173) was a popular Native American remedy for fever.